How to Use Gap Sense

A guide for people who will try the app.

This guide uses short sentences and simple words. It is written to be read with a screen reader, or read aloud to you.

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1. What this app is for

When you cross a street with no traffic light, you need to know one thing:

Do I have enough time to cross before that car arrives?

To answer that, you must know how long *your own* crossing takes. Not in seconds. As a feeling.

This app helps you build that feeling.

The app never tells you a number of seconds. It plays sounds instead. You hear how early or how late you were. You feel the size of the difference.

That is the whole idea. Do not count. Listen and feel.

Use this app with your Orientation and Mobility (O&M) Specialist. It does not replace their teaching. It does not cover all the skills you need to cross streets. The app tells you this the first time you open it. Press **I understand** to go on.

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2. What you will hear

The app uses a few sounds. Learn them first. It takes one minute.

Your own sound. A plain tone. It means “this is your time”. It plays back the moment you tapped, or where your crossing time ends.

The “good” sound. A short, high, bright chime. It means you were close enough.

The “not good” sound. A longer, low, buzzing sound. It means you were too far off.

The sample warning time. One steady sound. It stays at the same loudness from start to end, then stops. You hear it in parts 2 and 3.

“Get ready”. In part 2, the app says the words “Get ready” out loud.

The two feedback sounds are very different on purpose. One is short and high. One is long and low. You will not mix them up.

To hear them now: open **Help**, then press **Run the sound tutorial**. You can play each sound as many times as you like.

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3. The most important thing

In practice, you will hear **two sounds close together**:

1. your tap, and
2. the correct time.

Listen to the space between them.

- A small space means you were close.
- A big space means you were far off.

That space is the lesson. It is not a number. It is a feeling of time.

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4. Trying the app quickly

First, get the app on your phone. The short guide **How to Get Gap Sense on Your Phone** explains it: on iPhone through TestFlight, on Android as a file. Your instructor has it.

If your instructor sent you a setup link, open it now. It sets up the app for you. If the app was not installed when you first tapped the link, go back and tap it again. Then choose **Open in the Gap Sense app**.

If someone gave you a web link instead, open it. The app is ready to use straight away. It already has example times in it.

You can start pressing the button immediately.

5. Your crossing times

The app compares everything with your own crossing times. There are two:

- how long you take to cross the **first half** of the street, and
- how long you take to cross the **whole street**.

Your instructor measures these. They time you crossing a real street, several times, and use the longest. Then they type the times into the app's **Instructor setup**, or they send you a link. Open the link once. Your times are set. The link can also choose which parts and options you see.

You do not need to type any numbers.

Until your times are set, the four parts stay locked.

6. The four parts of the app

The app has four parts. They are numbered on the first screen. Do them in order. Your instructor may turn some parts off.

Part 1. Practice my timing

What it is for: to develop an accurate sense of your crossing times, through practice and feedback.

What you do:

1. Press the big button. This means "I am stepping off now."
2. Wait. Imagine yourself walking across.
3. Press the button again when you think you would have arrived.
4. Listen.

You will hear your two taps. Then you will hear the correct time.

Do not count seconds. Feel the time instead.

Do this many times. It becomes easier. A line under the button tells you how many of your last tries were close enough.

Part 2. Comparison preparation

What it is for: to get ready to compare your time with sample times. At a real street, nobody tells you when to start. You hear a car. You wait. Then you must judge: now is when I would finish crossing.

What you do:

1. Press the big button. It says **READY**.
2. The app says “Get ready”. Wait.
3. A steady sound starts. It is like hearing a car.
4. When you think you would finish crossing, press the button. The sound stops.
5. Listen.

You hear the sound, your press, and the correct time, like in part 1.

Sometimes the wait is short. Sometimes it is long. That is on purpose.

If you press before the sound starts, the app tells you it was too early. Nothing is saved. Just press **READY** again.

Part 3. Comparison practice

What it is for: to learn to compare a car’s warning time with your crossing time.

“Warning time” means: the time from when you first detect a car, by hearing or seeing it, until it passes in front of you.

What you do:

1. Press **Play a sample warning time**.
2. Listen to the sound. It is one steady sound. The length of that sound is the warning time.
3. A new screen fills the whole display. Answer: was it longer than your crossing, about the same, or shorter?

You can answer in two ways:

- Swipe anywhere on the screen. Swipe up for longer. Swipe down for shorter. Tap for about the same.
- Or press one of three buttons: **Longer than my crossing**, **About the same**, **Shorter than my crossing**.

If you use a screen reader, use the buttons. The focus lands on **About the same**. Flick once to reach the other two answers.

Right away, you hear if you were right. The good sound, or the not-good sound. If you turned on visual feedback, you also see a green circle or an orange triangle.

Then listen again. The app plays the sample and your crossing time together. The sample plays. Your own sound plays where your crossing time ends. If the sample ends first, it was shorter. If your sound comes first, it was longer. The space between them tells you how much.

How much longer or shorter? Your instructor may turn this on. It only comes after a right answer of longer or shorter. Tap once to start. Tap again when you think the difference is over. Then listen to the replay.

The app waits for you. Press **Play a sample warning time** again when you are ready for the next one.

Longer does not mean long enough. A warning time longer than your crossing time is not, by itself, enough to cross. Your O&M Specialist will teach you how to judge that, and all the other skills you need.

You can do this part anywhere. You do not need a street.

Part 4. At the street

What it is for: to get warning times of real vehicles, and compare them with your crossing time.

Stand where your O&M Specialist tells you. Do not step into the street.

What you do:

1. Choose **Hearing** or **Vision**: how you are detecting cars.
2. Press **START**. A new screen fills the whole display.
3. The moment you **think** you detect a car, swipe toward the side it is coming from. Swipe left if it comes from the left. Swipe right if it comes from the right.

4. Tap when the car **passes in front of you**.
5. If it never comes, swipe down.
6. Then answer: was that warning time longer than your crossing, about the same, or shorter? Answer the same way as in part 3.

The app does not tell you the answer first. You judge. Then you hear if you were right.

If you use a screen reader, there are buttons for each step: **Vehicle from the left**, **Vehicle from the right**, **It passed in front of me**, **It never came**.

Press **Done** when you finish.

The app does not use the microphone.

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7. Settings you may want

Open **Accessibility** from the top of the screen.

Sound, picture, or both. Choose what you want: - Audio only - Audio and visual - Visual only, with no sound

Vibration. It is on from the start. You feel the app as well as hear it. Press **Test haptic pulse** to try it. You can turn it off with **Vibrate on cue** if you prefer.

Vibration works in the installed app. It does not work in the Safari browser on iPhone. Apple does not allow it there.

Text size. You can make text much bigger, up to three times.

Speak directions aloud. The app can read its own directions out loud. This helps if you are still learning VoiceOver or TalkBack. You can choose a slower or faster speaking rate.

Colors. Choose light, dark, or yellow-on-black. There is also a high-contrast setting.

Announce cues. This is for screen reader users. It is on by default.

The app goes quiet during playback on purpose. Your screen reader will not talk over the sounds. This is not a fault. The sounds are the lesson.

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8. Useful advice

Never count. If you count, you are not learning the feeling. That is the whole point of this app.

Practice often, for a short time. Five minutes is better than one long hour.

Use headphones if it is noisy. But at a real street, do not cover your ears. You need to hear the traffic.

Your times change. If you are tired, or carrying bags, or the weather is bad, you walk slower. Ask your instructor to time you again when things change.

Different streets are different. A wide street takes longer. Your instructor can set new times for each street you use often.

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9. If something does not work

I hear no sound. Check the volume. In **Accessibility**, press **Play a test sound**.

I feel no vibration. Vibration only works in the installed app, not in the browser on iPhone. Check that **Vibrate on cue** is on. On iPhone, also check Settings, Accessibility, Touch, Vibration, and Settings, Sounds and Haptics, System Haptics.

The app says “Times needed”. Your crossing times are not set yet. Open the link your instructor sent you, or ask your instructor to enter the times in Instructor setup.

The buttons will not work. All four parts stay locked until your crossing times are set.

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10. Your privacy

Everything stays on your own phone.

- There is no account. You do not sign in.
- Nothing is sent anywhere.
- Your practice history is saved only on your phone.
- The app never stores your name. It uses a short code that your instructor chooses.

If you want to send your results to your instructor, you must choose to do it. Open **Progress** and press **Send my progress to my instructor**. The app shows you the whole message first. Press **Send it**, then choose Messages, Mail, or another app. It is never sent automatically.

You can delete everything at any time. Open **Progress**, then press **Delete all my practice history**.

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11. Quick summary

1. Learn the sounds.
2. Your instructor sets your crossing times.
3. Practice the feeling. Do not count.
4. Practice stopping the sound at your crossing time.
5. Practice comparing sample warning times.
6. Try it with real cars, where your instructor places you.

Listen to the space between the sounds. That space is the answer.